Polaris

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra)

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by Paganaidd

Summary

There was really only one adult whom Catra remembered fondly from her childhood.

Story based on Morag's "Things you could never say" universe.

Notes

This is a little epilogue to Morag's excellent Things You Could Never Say series. This could be read as a one-shot, but it will make far more sense if you head over there and read her series (I'll wait).

It was not that I found her ending lacking in any way; I just had this little addition in my head, and it would not leave me alone.

Morag, I hope you approve of this (seriously, if you do not care for it, I will take it down). Those darn origami cranes caught my imagination.

Betaed by Doc

See the end of the work for more notes

- Inspired by some things (only god can forgive) by Morag

Originally, Adora was supposed to come for the first day of school drop-off as well, but she needed to be at work early, and it was not as easy to change her schedule as it was for Catra.

"Are you sure you'll be okay?" Adora asked nervously as they got ready to go to their respective destinations. "I mean…"

"It's fine," Catra said, smiling slightly as she sat on the bathroom counter, already dressed in her business casual blazer and red blouse. "I think I can handle walking them in, and we signed all the forms last week."

"I know, but… "

Catra's hand stroked her cheek, and Adora realized she had been chewing on her lip. She took her wife's hand and kissed it.

"It'll be fine," Catra told her. "I'll drop them off and text you how it went. Kyle can handle shit until I get there."

Adora smiled, pulling on her scrub top. "Did you wake up Finn yet?"

Catra smiled a little sadly. "I didn't need to. They're already awake and sitting by the door."

Adora sighed. In other circumstances, she would have thought Finn was eager to go to school, but in the week since they were placed with them, it was clear that Finn had a streak of people-pleasing as wide as Adora's.

The child was indeed sitting in the living room in the big comfy chair, which they seemed to feel was their safe spot. They were dressed with their hair brushed and face washed, petting Melog, who purred like an engine.

"Good morning!" Adora said, smiling. "Are you hungry?"

Finn's eyes dropped, and they bit their lips. Adora's heart clenched, though she could not have said why. They shrugged and looked down at Melog in her lap.

Catra cleared her throat and said, "Hey, Finn? I'm going to make yogurt for myself. Do you want that, or would you rather have cereal?" She breezed past the child, beckoning them to the kitchen. "We've got to leave in half an hour, and we both need to eat and take our meds, okay?"

"Yes, ma'am," they said, getting up to follow her. "C-could I have cereal?"

Adora followed them to the kitchen, her heart swelling with fondness as she watched the little domestic scene.

Catra put Finn's Adderall dose into the little ceramic egg cup they had designated for that purpose and then put her own meds in hers. She put them on the table before going to the fridge and pulling the milk and yogurt out.

"Finn?" she asked. "Can you get the cereal and your bowl?" She nodded at the cupboard where they stored the Finn-friendly food.

"Okay." The child did as they were told and sat at the table.

"Do you want water or milk?"

"Milk, please."

Catra looked up sharply at Adora. "You're not leaving until you eat something either, young lady," she said, mock stern.

Finn smiled, covering their mouth with their hand, and Catra winked at them.

Beaming, Adora came into the kitchen and sat down with her own yogurt.

Catra swallowed her meds and went back to her yogurt. “So, I’ll come and get you this afternoon, Finn. All right? And then we can come straight home and get dinner started. Adora will be home after that.”

“Don’t you have to work?” Finn asked. For the past week, if Catra was there in the mornings, it meant she could not be home early.

“I’m going to work a half day today.”

The child stiffened. “Y-you don’t have to,” they muttered, rapidly eating their cereal. It made Adora’s stomach hurt a little. They always seemed to be steeling themselves for something.

Catra’s eyes flicked to Adora’s--she’d seen it too. In a deliberately casual way, she said, “No problem. I worked too many hours the week before last, so I have some I need to use up.” She looked at Adora, “Do you have anything you need on the shopping list?”

“Granola bars?”

Catra rolled her eyes good-naturedly. “Of course.” She finished her yogurt and stood up. You have ten minutes before we need to go, okay?” Catra said to Finn, not mentioning the meds in front of them. The child had resisted taking them at their last placement, or so the report read. Catra had come up with the idea that if she were open about taking her meds, maybe Finn would be more okay with it.

They had talked to the social worker about it, and she had agreed that normalizing taking meds might be helpful (it sounded like at least one of their placements had an attitude about meds being “a crutch”). Especially since Catra was open to talking about her recent diagnosis of ADHD and how the medication that she took to manage it improved her life so much.

Finn nodded and finished their cereal in about three bites. Adora was about to remind them about the little pill in the eggcup, but the child paused in the middle of picking up their bowl and instead grabbed the medication, swallowing it with a gulp of water.

Behind Finn, Catra broke into a huge smile and gave Adora a thumbs-up. They had both agreed not to make a big deal out of Finn's compliance. Catra said when someone praised her behavior too much when she was a kid, it scared her. It did not help that Weaver would save her nastiest remarks for those occasions, always saying she didn't want Catra to get "too big for her britches."

Finn took their bowl, glass, and eggcup to Catra, who put the bowl and glass in the dishwasher. "Thanks for the help, Finn," Catra said, beaming. "Can you put the egg cups back where they belong? I really appreciate that you remembered to take your meds." The medication bottles themselves were stored in a lock box on the highest shelf in the cupboard.

Adora remembered something, "Finn? Can I take a first day of school picture!"

The look on their face answered that, but they hesitantly began to nod. They had seen that a lot this week--Finn was unnaturally compliant about most things. Their social worker thought it was because the last foster home had been very strict.

Catra's jaw clenched, but she said lightly. "It's okay if you don't. I don't like being in pictures a lot of times, either. That is something you get to decide."

Slowly, Finn shook their head.

Adora could have cheered. It was the first time all week the child had said "no."

When her phone rang with the school's ringtone, Catra picked it up on the first ring, holding up a finger to silence Kyle as he explained some customer complaint. At least it got Catra out of dealing with that.

"This is Catra Guerra," she said Into the phone.

“Oh yes, Ms. Guerra. It’s Huntara Crimson at the school?”

Shit. Finn’s teacher was calling. On Finn’s first day.

“Ms. Crimson. Could you hold on a minute?” She muted the phone. “Sorry, it’s my foster kid’s school.” She told the man.

“Oh, yeah, of course. Do you want me to take care of this guy?” He pointed out the door towards the front of the store.

“You said he wanted to see the manager,” Catra replied, getting up, making sure her keys were in her pocket, and locking the computer. “Hate to tell you, but if I’m not here, you *are* the manager.” Kyle had only been made assistant general manager last month, and sometimes, he still forgot he actually had authority. “And I’m not here.”

She was already picking up her backpack and going out to the parking lot, glad she’d opted to wear a suit today. It gave her a little boost that she needed to face the fucking principal or whatever.

“Okay, Ms. Crimson. Go ahead,” she said as she walked out the back door to her car, her heart racing like the teacher was calling about her.

“Yes. We’ve had a little incident here. Finn’s been fighting with another student and gave them a bloody nose. We were wondering if you could come pick them up.”

“I’m on my way,” Catra said, feeling the blood drain from her face. Her stomach hurt. She shook her head, dismissing the memories of her own fights, focusing on the teacher’s words.

“Thanks,” the woman said warmly. “We had the resource officer take them down to the de-escalation room. I can meet you there.”

“I’ll be there in fifteen,” Catra said, her voice clipped.

“Talk to you then.”

Catra hung up her phone and put it in the holder before she started the car. Resource officer. The words made her stomach roil. If those bastards cuffed Finn, Catra was not sure what she was going to do. She reversed out of the parking space in a spray of gravel and hit the button to speed dial Adora as soon as she got to the stop sign.

“Catra, what's wrong?” Catra only called Adora at work if it was a real emergency.

“Finn got in a fight. The resource officer had to take them to the de-escalation room,” she said as she checked to see if anyone was coming, then she floored it onto the main street.

Adora swore softly. “I don’t think I can get away. Are you..?”

“Yeah, yeah. I’m fine. I’m headed there now. It’s just… You know.” Whenever Weaver had to pick Catra up because of a behavior issue, she would float in talking with the school staff. Making friends, everyone sympathetic to her plight. Weaver would have whole conversations about what a problem Catra was right in front of her. Then Catra would get into the back of Weaver’s car. Going home to take her punishment.

“Yeah.” For a second, the two women were quiet. Then Adora took a long breath on the other side of the line. “But you got this.”

“Adora, if they cuffed them…” Catra began, not sure where she was going with that, but she remembered the way she struggled and screamed, terrified that this time they were taking her to jail. Terrified she was never going to see Adora again and terrified that all the things Weaver said were true.

“If they cuffed Finn, you will call Finn’s social worker and get the state to investigate the school. Then, you are going to call Angella, and her lawyer will write a nastygram so scary they will piss their pants. And then probably the TV station,” Adora asserted. “And then, as soon as I get home, we’ll come up with more to do.”

The words were like a rope to a drowning person. That was absolutely what she was going to do. Catra was not a kid who had to take whatever the adults decided to give her.

And it's not her anyway. Finn was not the nightmare she was. Finn was a sweet, shy kid with much more in common with Adora. When Catra was six, she was already hostile and angry at everyone. At that age, she would calm down for Adora but absolutely no one else. She would bite, hit, and scratch at the drop of a hat. Everyone was cautious of her, never knowing when she would lash out.

This kid was not at all like she was. But that did not stop her from imagining the worst. Catra had been the scapegoat for a fight with another kid more than once. The teachers saw "Foster" in a file, and immediately, they became the classroom punching bag.

She screeched into the school parking lot at an unnecessary speed. The contrast between this place and her own school growing up struck her again. This school was clean, well-maintained, and looked like it had more resources than her entire school district had had.

She couldn't help but feel a pang of unease. She never told anyone but her therapist how insecure she was about her upbringing. Emily said it was natural, given the messages Catra got from Weaver about how she was "little better than an animal." Well, Adora knew. The trouble was that Adora was worse. She always had to be perfect. Weaver insisted on so many rules to follow that neither Catra nor Adora knew what rules real people in the real world followed.

Catra finally told Glimmer something about it: how she was always nervous about looking trashy by acting trashy. So, Glimmer referred Catra to Angella.

Angella looked at her gravely for a minute and said, "I have never found you anything but courteous, Catra, but I can lend you some books about the niceties. However, the truth is, to be a person of

influence, the most important thing you can do is believe in your right to occupy your space."

Well, Catra was ready to occupy all of her own space and more if Finn needed her to. Before she got out, she straightened her blouse and ran a brush through her hair, determined to look competent and together. Fake it 'til you make it, wasn't that what they said?

When she had walked Finn into school this morning, they had only wanted her to come to the door of the first-grade classroom. The teacher had walked over to greet Finn, so Catra had just waved goodbye.

It was 1:50 now. That beat Catra's record. Usually, it took a day or two before Catra got into a fight.

The front door was locked during school hours, so Catra pressed the doorbell. A man in uniform sat behind a desk. He pressed a button, and a tinny voice asked for her name.

"Catra Guerra," she said into the intercom.

He buzzed her in.

"Ms.Guerra." The man stood up and extended his hand. His name badge said, "Steve Hawk, Resource Officer. Thank you for coming." He had an engaging smile, But Catra was too keyed up for pleasantries.

"What happened with Finn?" Catra demanded.

"Well, I'm afraid they had words with one of their classmates, and then Finn hit her." His smile dropped. "Ms. Crimson and I broke it up. The other child went to the school nurse for a bloody nose.

"Where's his teacher?"

"She's in her classroom, but she said she'd be happy to meet you at the de-escalation room. I'll let her know you're here. She'll

explain how we handle this."

"So, they're being suspended?" Catra asked, tilting her chin up to glare at the man.

The officer gave a small, "what-can-you-do?" shrug and said, "Unfortunately, the district zero-tolerance policy for fighting requires that they leave for the rest of the day. However they can return tomorrow, and serve their detention in school."

"All right." It didn't sound like it was too bad, so Catra allowed herself a cautious sigh of relief. She hoped it wouldn't put Finn too out of sync with the rest of the class. But, on the other hand, the other kids learning that Finn didn't take any shit on the *first* day would probably prevent a lot of problems with the other kids later.

Not that Catra would ever say that out loud.

"So where do I need to go?"

Officer Hawk gave her directions and a visitor's pass.

Walking through the halls, Catra noticed once again the polished floors, the colorful posters, and the well-stocked classrooms glimpsed through open doors. She had opted for her suit this morning because she was doing the drop-off. When they first registered Finn, she and Adora talked about their own experience. What would it have been like if their schools had been like this? Would it have made any difference?

No matter what type of school, though, they always smelled the same. It was a cliche because it was true. Just as true was that an odor could be a shortcut to every bad memory.

She stopped outside of the open door. A woman's voice was talking softly. Catra held her breath, wanting to find out what was being said before the woman could put on the mask she wore for the parents.

“Hey, Officer Hawk, just let me know your foster mom is here. Why don’t we try to get your things together so we’re ready for her? Okay?” She sounded older. Competent and kind. Oddly familiar, but that was because all teachers sounded the same, really.

That was the wrong thing to say. Finn let out a long, sad wailing, “Noooooo!”

“Finn, my friend. What’s going on?” the woman exclaimed.

“I d-didn’t want you t--to call her! I was t-trying! It isn’t fair!” The rest of the words were lost to Finn’s sobs, and Catra’s heart broke into a million pieces. Long ago voices pressed forward in her mind. She remembered begging them not to call Weaver in that exact tone.

“I’m sorry, but we had to call her.”

Catra’s stomach twisted into knots.

“NOOO!” shrieked the child. “You can’t. You can’t. You can’t! Please!”

A scuffling sound, and then the woman cried, “Finn! Don’t!” The kid’s shrieking became piercing, and Catra felt her breathing speed up until she was almost hyperventilating. The sounds stopped, and the woman’s voice said, “You’re not allowed to hurt yourself, friend. That’s not okay.” Her voice remained firm and kind. Finn must have been banging their head on the floor. They had done it during the one epic meltdown Catra had seen.

Catra took a deep breath and stepped back to lean against the wall. Finn was safe, and Catra had her plans to deal with her own triggers. She took out one of the sour candies she always had in her backpack and popped it into her mouth. It would do none of them any good if Catra had a panic attack. The whole scene seemed ripped from her childhood.

What the fuck had made her think she could do this? She thought she'd gotten a handle on her anger issues, but last week had been stressful, and she and Adora had been snapping at each other. And then yesterday, she had had to drag Finn home from the playground, and they'd refused to eat at dinner. Then, she'd had a tense conversation with one of the shift managers on the phone. She had gotten heated, and she had probably scared the living shit out of the poor kid. She'd call the kid's social worker and see what they could do to find a more suitable placement and…

The shrieking calmed down more quickly than Catra thought it would. The poor thing must be half exhausted already.

"Okay. That's right. Slow down," the woman crooned. "You're okay."

Catra slid down the wall until she crouched and put her head in her hands. At least, the sound of the woman consoling Finn was reassuring.

The woman asked cautiously."Can you tell me why you don't want us to call your foster mom?"

Heart in her throat, Catra listened, ready to throw herself from the nearest bridge.

"If I'm a bad kid. They'll send me back," the child whimpered brokenly.

"Is that what they told you?"

"N-nuh-uh," Finn said. "B-but it's what always happens.

"Hmm. That sounds scary," the woman said. "Maybe we should…"

"Ma'am?" Catra jerked her head up at the voice. A woman taller than Scorpia looked down at her with concern. "Are you all right?"

Tears were running down Catra's face as she wept silently. Fuck. Hastily, she pushed herself to her feet and quickly wiped her eyes with the sleeve of her blazer. Fuck, she was a hot mess.

The woman was about Catra's age and wore the cardigan, T-shirt, and jeans combination that seemed to be the uniform of first-grade teachers everywhere.

"Y-yeah," Catra said quickly. "I just…" she cleared her throat. "I'm here to pick up Finn," she finished lamely.

The woman nodded like she had *not* just discovered Catra sitting on the floor, crying. "Yes, I was just coming down to talk to you. I'm Huntara Crimson." She put her head through the door of the de-escalation room. "Hey, Casta? Ms Guerra's here, but I need to talk to her for a bit. I won't keep her long." Then, the woman steered Catra into what looked like the teacher's lounge. She took a box of tissues from the table and handed them to Catra.

"You want some tea?" The big woman asked.

"Yeah. That'd be great," muttered Catra, wanting to disappear. If there were any justice in the world at all, a hole would open up in the ground and swallow her right this second. She wondered how many would-be foster parents washed out in the first month. "I'm sorry. I don't know why I'm like this."

Huntara filled a clean cup with hot water from the kettle with a tea bag and handed it over. Then she sat in the other chair. "First days are hard on parents," she said kindly. "And getting a call like this makes you feel like you've done something horribly wrong."

At that, Catra snorted wetly. "Yeah."

"Finn's a really sweet kid," the woman said. "How long has she been with you? I haven't had a chance to read any of her files." That made sense, the file had only just been sent.

"Them," Catra corrected automatically. "Finn uses they/them." She sipped her tea, glaring over the rim of the mug. The tea was too

hot, but that was good; her scalding mouth was something else that grounded her. “We’ve had them for about a week.”

“Ah. Okay, got it.” The teacher’s face cleared as if she was pleased to be corrected. “That would explain some things. Is this your first foster placement?”

Blowing on her tea, Catra nodded.

The woman looked sympathetic. “Yeah, it’s tough. But I’m sure it's just a bump in the road. I’m really not surprised at the acting out. It’s typical with new placements. We would not have called you except for the hitting.” Ms. Crimson shrugged. “And when I talked to some of the other kids, it sounded like the other one was looking for a fight.”

“Oh?” Catra raised an eyebrow.

“Just some mean girl garbage.” Huntara sighed. “Finn mentioned that they had two moms during sharing time. At lunch, the other kid had a problem with that. Unsavory words about lesbians were used.”

Oh shit. Catra knew that was a possibility, but she had not really expected it. Bright Moon was so much more progressive than where she grew up.

“So, I have explained that those are not okay words to use here.” The woman smiled slightly. “I don’t allow that kind of thing in my classroom. Especially since I resemble that remark.”

Catra smiled a little.

“So, what’s the plan for Finn now?” Catra asked.

“I’d recommend an early story and bedtime and just come back tomorrow. The other mom said that the other student involved has a history of bloody noses from the slightest bump, so it looked a lot worse than it was.” The woman grimaced. “And the other child has had some stress at home lately, so really it is not a huge

issue in the grand scheme of things. I'll keep an eye on them both."

Catra's stomach untwisted, and to her horror, tears started down her face again. Until that moment, Catra had not realized she was expecting to be told Finn had seriously injured the other kid. Her relief was so strong and sudden that she felt nauseous.

"I'm sorry about this," Catra muttered, wiping her eyes. "I just…"

"Hey, no worries. Fostering is tough. And, although I haven't read it, Finn's file looked extensive when I brought it up on the computer. That's hard for someone their size." Ms. Crimson leaned forward to take Catra's tea cup. "And the first call home from school is always pretty upsetting." Tactfully, she pretended not to notice Catra's tears.

"So, what happens now?"

"He has a five-hour, in-school suspension. It's spread out over the week, so they don't get behind in class. The detention is spent with one of our behavioral team."

Okay, that sounded sane.

Catra's phone rang. "Oh, I need to get this. It's Finn's other foster mom." She picked up. "Hey, Adora."

"How's Finn?" she demanded. "I just got finished. Do you need me to leave early? I can if you need me."

"I'm talking to Finn's teacher. I think you're fine to come home at the regular time. Although we're ordering out."

"Indian or pizza?" Adora asked.

"Oh, it's definitely an Indian night for me." Butter chicken was Catra's go-to comfort food for some reason. Maybe because the first time she had it was when she and Adora moved in together. "But we better ask Finn what they want."

"Okay. Love you. Bye."

"Love you." Catra ended the call.

Ms Crimson smiled and said, "I knew an Adora once. Did she play field hockey for Bright Moon?"

Catra smiled back. The expression did not feel unnatural now. "Yes, she did. She had to quit when she got injured."

"Yeah, I heard about that. I played for The Waste." Ms. Crimson grinned. "Finn says you two are married?"

Catra nodded.

"Oh, that's great! She always seemed like mom material." Ms Crimson glanced at the clock, then stood. "It's getting late. We can talk more another time. I've got to get back."

Running her hand through her hair, Catra stood and followed the big woman.

"Casta? I'm done with Ms. Guerra." The teacher called in the door, then waved at Catra as she strode back down the hallway. "Tell Adora I said 'hi! And I'll see you both at Back to School Night?"

Catra nodded. That had been unexpectedly pleasant. She wondered how many times Weaver received tea and sympathy from her teachers.

When Catra went into the classroom, she only had eyes for poor Finn, who sat disconsolately under some sort of play stand with a canopy draped over it, idly running their hand through a box full of dried beans. "Hey, buddy," she said. "I hear you're having a rough day." She crouched and sat on the carpet.

The child did not speak or look at her, but they shrugged to show they heard.

"Oh, Ms. Guerra, I'm Casta Torres. I…"

Catra's breath caught in her throat, and she froze like a rabbit. That voice could not possibly be who it sounded like. Her head whipped around to meet the gaze of the woman who had witnessed some of the worst collateral damage of Stella Weaver's parenting methods. 'Ms. Torres?' she whispered, her heart racing.

The woman saw Catra's eyes and gasped, "Catra? Catra Guerra?"

"Ms Torres?" Catra said blankly.

"Oh, my goodness! I didn't even see your first name on Finn's file. I had no idea!" The woman looked unaccountably delighted, and she grinned. "How are you?" she paused. "You look well!"

The woman must have been worried by the amount of time Catra spent with her mouth hanging open. Her smile faltered, and she repeated, "Catra?"

"Oh! Sorry. I wasn't expecting to run into anyone I knew." Catra felt like she wanted to cry again, but she shoved it down for Finn's sake. Ms Torres had been witness to her worst behaviors and meltdowns all through elementary school. Rare was the day that she did not spend some time with the woman. She wiped her sweaty palm on her pant leg.

"It's great to see you!" the woman's voice sounded sincere. "And now you're fostering children? That's wonderful! Finn said that they haven't been with you long?"

"N-no." Catra stuttered, feeling blindsided, wondering which horrible episode the woman was replaying in her mind and how she could lie that convincingly. But she remembered that the woman had been good at lying. Was she going to call Finn's social worker and explain just how crazy Catra was?

"Hey, Finn?" Catra said, trying to distract herself from her spiral. "Do you have your stuff? We should get going in about five minutes."

"Ms. Catra?" Finn said in a small voice. "I need the bathroom."

That broke through Catra’s paralysis. “Hey, yeah, dude. Go do that, and I’ll finish up with Ms. Torres.” She turned back to the other woman. “That okay?”

The other woman grinned. “Of course.”

When Finn had slipped out the door, Ms. Torres said, “Finn is very worried about how you’re going to react to this.”

“Not like Weaver did,” Catra said, crossing her arms and looking away.

The woman’s face fell. “Oh,” the word carried more grief than Catra ever imagined someone could convey in one syllable. "I was not even thinking of that. No, they're afraid you'll send them away."

Catra’s gaze snapped to the woman’s face, shocked to see her eyes brimming with tears. “What?”

"I think they're afraid this placement is too good to be true. They're afraid you'll send them back if they're bad."

That made Catra feel better about life. "We're not sending them anywhere."

"That's good to hear." Then Ms. Torres's face sobered, and she said in a low voice, “I read in the news that you brought charges against Stella Weaver a few years ago.”

Catra met the woman’s eyes “Yes.” She held her breath. Most people who knew Weaver had been shocked by the charges and then by the verdict. Catra waited to hear, “I can’t believe it,” or “We had no idea” she had received from others..

“Good for you.” Mrs. Torres’ smile turned as close to vindictive as so kind a face could be. “She was… not my favorite person,” The words were stony, and then she bit her lip. “I’m sorry that I couldn’t have done more for you and your foster sisters.”

Had she followed the trial? Why? Catra was vaguely aware a few local articles had been written about it, but they barely made a ripple in Bright Moon's press.

Ms. Torres huffed a little sigh and glanced apologetically at the door. "This isn't the time for this. Here." the woman scribbled on a sticky note and handed it to Catra. "That is my personal number. If…" she swallowed, "If you are interested in talking to me about anything."

"Okay." Bemused, Catra took the little pink note.

"In the meantime." The woman cleared her throat, returning to business. "Ms Crimson explained what is to happen?"

"She did," Catra affirmed. "Are you the person they're going to be with?"

"Yes." Ms. Torres paused. "As long as that's okay with you, of course."

A weight lifted from Catra's heart. Unless Ms. Torres had gotten brain damage or something, it was the best thing Catra could think of. "Oh, yeah. That's great." She grinned.

Looking reassured, Ms. Torres said, "You really do look well, Catra. Also, please. I mean it. If you want to talk, please call."

Finn returned from the bathroom, and their conversation turned back to Finn's detention. Ms. Torres explained that Finn should go to his regular class in the morning, and she would come and get him.

As they walked out to the parking lot, Finn's hand was cold in hers, and he was trembling. That made Catra's heart hurt.

"Are you mad at me?" Finn asked when they got to the car, their voice and face perfectly blank

“Not gonna lie,” Catra sighed. “I can’t say I’m thrilled. But we’ll talk about it with Adora when we get home.”

“Am I… ?” Finn starts nervously after Catra buckles them in.

“Gonna get punished?” Catra finished for them. She did not answer until she had shut Finn’s door and then walked all the way around to the driver's seat, thinking through what their parenting classes and the social workers said. “It’s just not okay to go around hitting people.”

“But they said… “

Catra glanced at them in the rear view and they froze instantly."I know they said something nasty. And its okay that you got pissed, but next time, try telling Ms. Crimson first. Okay?"

"Are you gonna call Miss Fredericks?"

"About this? Probably. But only because we would want to make sure she knows that I came and took care of it, okay?"

"Is she going to come get me?"

“Absolutely not," Catra said firmly. "Stuff happens, right? I don't just quit because someone makes a mistake, okay? Right now, we’re going to go home and talk about this. And then we’re going to order dinner. You can choose pizza or Indian food. And when Adora gets home, we'll talk about what happened.”

Their talk lasted through dinner and mostly consisted of Catra and Adora letting Finn know that nothing terrible was going to happen. Once they had eaten and gone through their nighttime routine, Catra told Adora about who she had met that day.

“Holy shit!” Adora spat more loudly than she intended. She clapped her hand over her mouth, and they both looked worriedly at Finn’s door for a moment. For some reason, Adora’s cheeks had gone bright red.

“Wow.” She went on more quietly when it became apparent Finn was not going to make an appearance. “Huntara teaching at Finn’s school makes sense. She was studying education.” Adora exclaimed. “But, Mrs. Torres! Here in Bright Moon? That’s crazy.”

“I know, right?”

“Are you going to call her?”

Catra hesitated. “Do you think I should?”

“I don’t know. Maybe ask your therapist?”

“She’ll just ask me what I want to do.”

What did Catra want? The offer was tempting, but what would be the point? Another well-meaning person awkwardly explaining they had “no idea” that Weaver was an evil cunt? No, it was no good opening that can of worms. Best to let it lie.

Ms Torres never sought her out either, even though Catra did pick up most days,

After the initial bumpy start, Finn seemed to be settling down, and little by little, they were opening up to both Catra and Adora. Their routine had solidified so that, for now, they didn’t need any childcare. Catra started work at 6:30, so she could be out at three o’clock. The school had an afterschool program that ran until four, Although Catra was usually there by three fifteen. Most nights, Adora’s schedule had her home in time for supper, but she usually had one or two late nights a month when Catra and Finn were on their own for dinner.

On one of those nights, Catra had been late picking Finn up. Even though she had called ahead to let the school know and arrived well before after-school ended, she had arrived to find Finn in tears. They cried quietly while getting their things and climbing into their car seats.

They were halfway home when the tears turned to sobs and then into a blood-curdling scream. “WHERE WERE YOU?” the child shrieked, kicking the back of the passenger seat.

Catra pulled over. “Finn!” Catra cried, whirling around, adrenaline making her voice louder than she meant it. Her hands were shaking on the wheel.

The volume of her voice had an immediate effect. The kid’s eyes squinched, and their face turned away with tears and snot mixing, shaking as if they were possessed. They threw a hand up to protect their head and curled in on themselves, sobbing incoherent apologies.

Catra sucked in a huge breath. “Listen, this is important. Look at my face.” She waited until Finn looked. It took a minute for them to come out of their defensive huddle. “I cannot drive this car if you do that. You scared me. Got it?”

The kid nodded, hiccuping.

“Do you think you can hold it together until we get home?” Without waiting for an answer, she turned around and started driving. The child cried quietly in the back, and it made Catra’s stomach hurt.

When they got home, Finn climbed out of his seat and darted from the car as soon as Catra opened the door. Once inside, they slammed their stuff down, and then they screamed.

Catra’s mind blanked. None of the parenting classes had prepared her for this. For one terrible second, she remembered Weaver’s hand in her hair, throwing her to the ground.

She took a deep breath like Emily taught her to. *In one-two-three-four.* A few of those helped her get her own shit under control.

Finn was safe; they weren’t doing anything scary; they were just screaming. She put her bag down. “Wow, that’s a big feeling,” she said, mostly to herself because there was no way Finn could hear

her. They had thrown themselves on the floor, gasping and sobbing uncontrollably.

Finn’s file had said they were prone to tantrums, but this was the first since their first week. She went with the social worker's suggestion: “It sounds like you’re really overwrought. I think you need a few minutes of quiet time.”

More sobbing and deliberately turning away so they did not have to look at her.

Ookay.

"Hey, kiddo, I'm going to carry you," she warned. She hoisted them up on her hip and carried them, literally kicking and screaming, to their room. She set them on the bed, closed the blinds, and turned on the nightlight with its soothing color changes. and then flopped down beside it on the floor. Fuck it, she was tired.

After a while, Finn’s cries slowed, then stopped. After another minute, the kid poked their head over the side of the bed to look at Catra and see where she lay.

“What are you doing there?” they asked, snuffling.

“You seemed like you were having some big feelings. I stayed to make sure you stayed safe.”

“Why?”

“Cause I like you, silly. I want you to stay safe.” She got up. “Let’s go have a snack and talk about today. Okay?”

The child nodded dubiously.

“Do you need help washing your face?”

Solemnly, they shook their head.

"Okay, go wash up, and I'll be in the kitchen."

One crisis was dealt with. Catra went to the kitchen, took an iced tea from the fridge, and sat down. Her nerves were jangled, and her head hurt. Idly, she picked up a piece of paper and started making a crane. She always found it soothing.

Fold, crease, fold.

Finn came in and went to their snack drawer. The poor thing moved silently as though they did not want to draw attention, so Catra continued to work on her origami.

Fold. Fold again.

Finn brought their snack to the table. “What are you doing?”

“Making a bird.”

Finn watched her finish it. Catra handed it to them. “I can show you if you want.”

The kid’s eyes lit up, and they nodded. Catra started another crane and then a third as she showed Finn how it was done.

“There’s lots of other things you can make, too,” Catra said. “Ms.Torres taught me.”

“You really knew Ms. Torres when you were a kid?” asked Finn as they clumsily folded their first crane.

“Yeah. She was doing the same job at my school.” Catra said.

Ms. Torres taught me.

Those words felt enormous.

Ms. Torres had been a fixture in Catra’s life for six years. As a foster kid diagnosed with oppositional defiant disorder, she had an IEP that was just full of “tough love.” Catra had no idea what Ms

Torres's title had been then. She just knew that the hours spent in Ms. Torres' office had been some of the best of her childhood.

Ms Torres had taught Catra to fold origami. She had tubs full of rice or beans that Catra used to bury her hands in, letting the feel of it running out of her hands soothe her. She had held Catra in a bear hug when Catra had been determined to scratch long bloody lines in her arms. When Catra was excluded from activities or deprived of recess, she would hang out with Mrs. Torres who always seemed an unending font of patience. In the confines of the woman's little resource room, Catra felt *safe.*

Making the phone call felt insurmountable, so Catra texted:

Ms. Torres? This is Catra.

Hello!

Do you have a few minutes to talk tomorrow? Not about Finn though

I can arrange it. Does just before pickup work? 2:30?

Yes. See you then

The next day, Catra went to work an hour early. She sat in the office, distracting herself with inventory reports and making new orders, but she felt anxious. More than once she reached for her phone to cancel the meeting, but that felt cowardly.

She had told Adora about the meeting before bed last night. "I want it to be tomorrow, or I'll change my mind," Catra said. "I just

want to know what she’s got to say, you know?”

“Call me, if you need to,.” Adora said.

At two o’clock, Catra left work and pulled into the school at two fifteen. Ms. Torres waited at the door to let her in. She smiled broadly as though pleased to see Catra. It was the same expression Catra remembered from the days she randomly wandered to the woman's little classroom during lunch.

Apart from a muttered greeting Catra couldn’t find anything to say until they arrived at Ms Torres’ room.

This was a terrible idea. This was a mistake. Catra shook her head, wondering what the fuck she had been thinking? What the actual fuck did she think she was going to get out of this?

The door closed behind them, and Ms Torres gestured to a pair of adult-sized chairs near the desk. “Catra, I’m so glad you agreed to see me.”

“Hey. No problem.” Catra felt lightheaded. She couldn’t find a thing to say. Why was she here again? She sat down on the chair more heavily than she meant to.

For a second, they sat in awkward silence, and then it seemed like Ms. Torres could not stand it anymore.

“I’m so sorry, Catra.” The woman blurted. “I-I knew Weaver was bad,” she spoke quickly as if trying to get the words out before she lost her nerve. “I wrote so many reports. I let you down, and I’m sorry.”

“I-what? But…” Catra sputtered, taken aback.

“When I read about the trial, I wanted to reach out, but I was afraid…” she trailed off, apparently running out of steam.

Catra couldn’t move or speak, her mind a jumble of memories. Hours spent in Ms. Torres's room were a respite for the rest of her

life. She would admire Catra's drawing and welcome her fumbling attempts at helping.

Catrea cleared her throat. "Why did you want to talk to me?" Her voice sounded small.

"I just… I guess I wanted to… I know no apology is ever going to be adequate, but I wanted to try." Her eyes welled with tears.

"To apologize? To me?" Catra could not have heard that right, but the woman wrung her hands together anxiously.

"Yes. I'm so sorry we failed you." Her expression was both angry and sad. "I saw it. I knew something terrible was happening, but no one wanted to listen. They'd see that ODD diagnosis in the file, and nothing I said could change their minds."

Catra knew that all too well. She and other clients had brought a lawsuit against the DCFS. The lawyers had discovered a pattern of workers dismissing reports of negligent or abusive caregivers in cases where the child was diagnosed with oppositional defiant disorder. Then there was the evidence that Latino children (especially those with darker skin) were disproportionately diagnosed with ODD, and it was no wonder Weaver got away with what she did.

"It's okay." That was a stupid thing to say, but Catra could not think of anything else. "You shouldn't… I mean, there's a lot of people who owe people apologies, but you're not one," she croaked around the lump in her throat. This was not what Catra had expected. The floor should not feel like it was dropping out from underneath her.

Shit.

She was crying again; ugly crying, tears running down her cheeks, shoulders shaking. A box of Kleenex landed in her lap. Her sobs were silent, as they always were. A cold glass of water was pressed into her hand.

“Catra?” asked Miss Torres. She looked so stricken that Catra struggled to shove her tears back. To get enough breath to explain.

“S-sorry about this,” Catra said hoarsely. “It’s just…”

It’s just that Catra remembered that Ms. Torres’s room always had cereal and milk to eat. How Ms. Torres never yelled at her, even when Catra was a hissing ball of anger and spite. Ms. Torres never mocked her for crying. Ms. Torres had always acted like Catra was just another kid, not some feral animal.

“Y-you taught me to make cranes,” Catra sobbed, knowing she was not making any sense, but she could not find the words to explain. Ms. Torres used to slip them into her backpack for Catra to find. Or maybe she only did it once, but ever after, Catra would leave little paper cranes in Adora’s things.

Sucking in the air, wrestling her runaway emotions under control, she was able to say, “I still make them.”

Ms. Torres’s face lit up. “Really?”

“You have no idea how much that meant.” Catra did not know how to explain that every time Adora was sad, Catra would try to remember what Ms. Torres might say. Ms Torres would hang tests that Catra did well on or drawings she was proud of up on the student bulletin board in the decompression room. There were things that Ms. Torres had done for Catra that were probably not even legal. Catra definitely remembered Motrin being given from Miss Torres’s purse when Catra had a broken arm. Weaver had “forgotten” to sign the form that would have allowed the school nurse to give it from the health room.

“I’m sorry.” Catra had finally stopped sobbing.

Ms. Torres’s face softened further. “I’m so glad you remember that. I’m glad I could help in some way.”

Help in some way? Catra's world turned on its axis. A lot of things she never thought about crowded into her head.

"You helped so much." Adora had been Catra's sun and moon, but for a few years, Ms. Torres had been Catra's North Star, Catra realized. With so few examples in her life, she could have become what her mother was, what Weaver wanted her to be. Ms. Torres was a safe adult who showed her kindness without any expectation that Catra would pay for it. When Catra was in Ms. Torres's room, she mattered.

Ms. Torres leaned forward to take Catra's hand. "You were such a strong kid. And you were so smart. When the complaints went nowhere, I did my best to help." She looked away. "I had to be careful. I got that job right out of school. If it happened now, I'd know what to do and who to call, but at the time? I was a first-year teacher when you were in kindergarten." She shook her head. "I did everything wrong. And they saw me as the stupid young teacher who needed to figure out there are some kids you just can't reach."

"Weaver used to like to say that," Catra said.

"Yes." Ms. Torres shifted in her chair. "I'm glad you think of me fondly. I wasn't sure if I'd bring back too many bad memories."

"No. It helps, I think." Catra said, feeling a little empty now that the storm of her emotions had passed. "Um. If you followed the trial, you probably know the… uh… nature of the charges."

Solemnly, Ms. Torres nodded, then said in a choked voice, "I first noticed that you had some concerning scenarios when you played pretend when you were halfway through first grade. And then you told me about the monster in your basement."

Did she? Catra couldn't remember.

"You told me the monster had a red mask and tied you down with shadows." The woman took a deep breath. "When I reported it, I was told that you had a tendency towards violent fantasy play."

Both statements sounded right.

“After the investigation, the school board did a purge of staff they saw as complicit.”

“Complicit?”

“Well, not legally complicit, but morally. I went to that board meeting to speak. I had a decade of documentation by that time. Including those two new fosters DCFS was stupid enough to give her,” Ms. Torres said, grimacing.

Catra nodded soberly, then glanced at her watch. She still had a few minutes.

Ms. Torres saw the gesture. “Finn talks about you and Adora all the time. They seem very happy.”

“Yeah? That’s good to hear. They had an epic meltdown last night. That’s why I thought about the cranes.” Catra smiled. “Our friends made us a thousand for our wedding.”

“Those sound like good friends.” Ms. Torres said, sounding pleased.

“They are.” Catra found herself beaming stupidly as she thought about them. “They’re the best.”

“And you and Adora? You're married? How is Adora?”

“She’s great. We’re both really good.”

"You look so good." Ms. Torres’s smile widened. “You were always a wonderful kid. I’m just so proud of you.”

End Notes

In this AU, Castaspella is Ms. Torres. No relation to Micah.

Shout out to all the teachers, librarians, and other school staff who make their classrooms, offices, and libraries safe and welcoming to all students. You have saved more lives than you will ever know. Thank you!

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